

House of Horror

A crafty tale succeeds in making a hero out of a villain



FAMILIES AT HOME

by REETI GADEKAR

HarperCollins

Price: Rs 295

Pages: 266

■ **By Bunny Suraiya**

In a macabre coincidence linking it to current headlines, the investigation on which this police-whodunnit centres is the murder of the daughter of a Delhi family by the name of Talwar. Who is the murderer? A member of the family? Or a servant? The investigating officer, Additional Joint Commissioner Nikhil Juneja, is in the hot seat, as he is pressurised by the commissioner to close the case fast, and with the minimum amount of embarrassment to an influential family.

Juneja, the estranged scion of a rich industrialist, is a bundle of contradictions: 'A colonial education and a policeman, an Indian and intelligent, 40 and alone'. He is also cynical, corrupt, and power-addicted. And yet, as he struggles to reconcile his westernised upbringing and leisure pursuits with the sordid, sweaty realities of his life as a Delhi policeman ('The future held Indi-Pop, Bollywood, chicken tikka and milky masala tea'), the skill of the writer makes you actually like him, sympathise with his predicaments and laugh along with him as he extracts a savage humour from the situations in which he finds himself and his own, often derailed, thinking processes.

This is no mean feat. To successfully turn the reader's mind in favour of a villain calls for superb craft and empathy, and a keen understanding of the society. Gadekar has a superb ear for dialogue and a gift for discerning the ridiculous in Delhi's social scene. As Juneja rosters up and down the city he loves and hates in equal measure, stalking into homes, lives and families in quest of booze, sex, freebies and, of course, the murderer, the reader goes along with him, fully enjoying the company of this unlikely hero, who makes you befriend him despite yourself. ■

TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (10)	The 3 Mistakes of My Life	Chetan Bhagat	Rupa
2. (1)	A Prisoner of Birth	Jeffrey Archer	Pan Macmillan
3. (-)	Brida	Paulo Coelho	HarperCollins
4. (2)	Unaccustomed Earth	Jhumpa Lahiri	Random House
5. (3)	The Appeal	John Grisham	Arrow Books/ Random House UK

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (9)	Superstar India: From Incredible to Unstoppable	Shobhaa De	Penguin
3. (4)	The Monk Who Sold His Ferrari	Robin S. Sharma	Jaico
4. (3)	We Are Like That Only: Understanding the Logic of Consumer India	Rama Bijapurkar	Penguin
5. (-)	The New Age of Innovation: Driving Co-Created Value Through Global Networks	C.K. Prahlad/ M.S. Krishnan	Tata McGraw Hill

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (-)	One Night@The Call Centre	Chetan Bhagat	Rupa
7. (-)	Five Point Someone: What Not to Do at IIT	Chetan Bhagat	Rupa/Simon & Schuster

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (-)	The Kalam Effect	P.M. Nair	HarperCollins
7. (-)	Entry From Backside Only	Binoo K. John	Penguin
8. (5)	The Elephant, the Tiger and the Cell Phone	Shashi Tharoor	Penguin
9. (-)	Who Will Cry When You Die?	Robin S. Sharma	Jaico

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead